RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO THE MISHNAH

Why Was the World Created? The Purpose of Man

Rambam's Intro to the Mishnah, Part 7

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to the Commentary on the Mishnah (Rav Shilat's edition), section ו: the purpose of creation and of the human being

Shiur: Part 7 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to the Mishnah, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 1 July 2025 (week of Parashat Chukat)

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Recap

We're nearing the end of the introduction: the transmission of the Oral Torah; prophets and Sages; how law developed; the purpose and structure of the **Mishnah**; then the **Talmud** and Ravina and Rav Ashi's four purposes: **explain, rule, record developments, and *derashot***.

Last week: aggadah looks simple, sometimes bizarre, but holds **great depth**. The Sages wrote cryptically (1) to invite **diverse interpretation**, (2) to keep deep truths from **undeveloped minds**, and (3) because it was written **for everyone, children included**. If a statement seems absurd, **blame yourself**, pray for ***siyata dishmaya***, and remember the man who knows every science but astronomy. **Never mock the Sages.**

The cliffhanger: אין לו להקב״ה בעולמו אלא ארבע אמות של הלכה בלבד. It seems to say *only the law matters*, against everything the Rambam teaches. Before explaining it, he **goes back to fundamentals: the purpose of creation and of the human being.**

Part 1: Everything Has a Purpose

דע כי החכמים... כבר בארו שכל דבר נמצא יש לו בהכרח תכלית אשר בשבילה היתה מציאותו.

Everything that exists necessarily has a purpose for which it exists.

Things people make

Nothing is manufactured for no reason:

Tool	Purpose
Saw (made by the smith)	To **saw**
Axe	To **cut**
Needle	To **join cloth**

Things Hashem made

Trees, grasses, minerals, springs, stones, animals: what are they for?

Some	**Easy** to see
Some	Need **much investigation**
Some	**Hidden and subtle**, knowable only **through prophecy**

Who can say why some ants have wings and others don't? Why some creatures have many legs, like the centipede, and others few? What is this worm, this ant, for?

The wiser you are, the more purposes you know: **ככל שיהיה יותר מלומד וחזק השקידה וזך השכל, ידע תכלית יותר דברים**.

Shlomo HaMelech knew the purpose of every species, as far as a person can: **וידבר על העצים מן הארז אשר בלבנון ועד האזוב... ועל הבהמה ועל העוף ועל הרמש ועל הדגים**, "a sign that he had divine power." **ויבאו מכל העמים לשמע את חכמת שלמה.**

The general rule: everything below the moon is for the human

כל הנמצאים מתחת גלגל הירח, אמנם הם נמצאו בשביל האדם בלבד.

Note the limit: "under the moon," meaning **planet Earth**.

	Purpose of the whole universe
Rav Saadia Gaon (*Emunot veDeot*, essay 4; "those on Monday nights")	Everything, **planets and stars included**, is for the human
The Rambam	**Rejects that.** Only what's **on Earth** is for the human

Examples:

- **Animals:** some for **food** (cattle); some for **work**: **donkeys** carry loads, **horses** cover distances, "the cars of those days."

- **Plants:** some for **food** (fruit), some for **medicine**.

- **Where we see no use: הרי זה לחולשת דעתנו**: it's **our ignorance**. From the elephant to the smallest worm, each has a purpose for us.

His proof: in every generation the uses of plants and animals are discovered that earlier generations didn't know. No single person can grasp all of them; knowledge **builds generation on generation**.

And poisons? Even deadly herbs have uses: applied to the body, apparently medicinal. **A snake** is venomous, yet useful (things are made from it).

Part 2: Then What Is the Human For?

If everything is for the human, we must ask: why does the human exist, and what is his purpose?

Animals and plants have one or two functions: the **palm** gives dates; the **spider's web** teaches weaving; the **swallow** "can help build." **A human does many different things.** So the philosophers examined every human action, and **concluded there is one final purpose**; everything else (eating, drinking, pleasure) is **to keep us alive** so we can reach it:

והוא ציור המושכלות וידיעת האמיתות כמות שהן.

Grasping intellectual truths, and knowing reality as it is.

Why not eating, building or ruling?

It can't be to eat, drink, procreate, build a wall or be a king, for (1) **these are accidents that add nothing to his essence**, and (2) **animals share every one of them**. Animals have kings too: "the **lion king**, hierarchies in every species."

Wisdom is what **changes a person's very being**, moving him **from a lowly state to an elevated one, from potential to actuality**:

כי האדם קודם שישכיל אמנם הוא כבהמה.

Before a person develops his intellect, he is like an animal. "Think of a baby: eats, drinks, excretes. That's it." **אין האדם נבדל משאר בעלי החיים אלא בהגיון**: we're **rational** beings.

And the highest knowledge

והנכבד שבמושכלות: ציור אחדות השם יתברך ויתרומם, ומה שכרוך בזה מן האלהיות. לפי ששאר החכמות אינן אלא להתלמד בהן כדי להגיע לחכמה האלהית.

The most important thing to understand is **the unity of Hashem**, and all of theology. **All other disciplines** (mathematics, astronomy, which the Rambam loved, the sciences) **exist to bring us to the knowledge of God.**

The pyramid

Level	
Top	**Understanding Hashem**
Middle	**Developing the intellect**: every discipline, every course of study
Base	**Functions shared with animals**: eating, drinking, procreating, entertainment, which keep us alive for the above
Beneath us	Everything on Earth, which exists **for the human**

Class comment: "So we're the kings of the world." "Correct, but **for what?** To use the world around us to develop the intellect, and **through it, our understanding of the Divine and of reality**."

Part 3: You Can't Grow Without Saying No

בציור המושכלות יחויב להרחיק ההפרזה בהנאות הגשמיות.

Developing the intellect requires **distancing oneself from excess in physical pleasure.**

If a person **chases desires**, **gives priority to sensation** and **enslaves his intellect to his appetites**, **he is like an animal**; nothing divine can be seen in him, and he becomes mere matter that perishes, **שוחה בים ההיולי**: **"swimming in the sea of matter."** "**Beautiful phrase.**"

This week's parashah, Chukat

in context, the law of one who dies **in a tent**. The Sages (Berachot 63b): :**זאת התורה אדם כי ימות באהל**
.the Torah endures only in one who "kills himself" in the tent of Torah

What it doesn't mean: cutting yourself off from the world. **"100%"**: the Rambam **never** believed in denying the basic things of life, and "**hated**" fasting and self-affliction.

What it does mean: anything worth achieving requires some self-denial.

"Leave Torah aside. You want to become a professor, you're doing your **A-levels**, your degree, your exams: *I can't watch that film tonight; I can't go out with my friends; I need to study.* Wise people recognise it's worth it. A lot of people don't, **which is why they don't study and end up undeveloped.**"

"**My stomach is rumbling**, but I'm in the middle of a shiur, trying to understand something: I'll eat in an hour. I'd love to go to the cinema with friends tonight, **but I want to learn a bit.** It's a negation. That's the reality of life in every discipline, and certainly in Torah."

Part 4: The Purpose of Earth Is a Wise and Good Person

הנה יתבאר מכל ההקדמות כי תכלית עולמנו ומה שבו אמנם הוא איש חכם וטוב.

The purpose of our world (again: **our world**, not the universe, against Rav Saadia) **is a wise and good person.**

When one person achieves both wisdom and action:

	Meaning
חכמה, wisdom	understanding reality as it truly is, **as far as humanly possible**: **ציור האמיתות כמות שהן**
מעשה, action	**balance** in natural things, **יושר המזג**; **no addictions**: taking from the physical, **הרחקת ההתמכרות**, only **what the body needs**; and **צדק המדות כולן**, refined character

Wisdom **must** include action: **כל שחכמתו מרובה ממעשיו, אין חכמתו מתקיימת**.

The Chida and his snuff. Rav Chaim Yosef David Azulai (1700s) wrote this in his diary. Snuff and tobacco were new and popular, and **he enjoyed it a lot**. Staying in someone's home, he **got up at night to get some**, and realised he'd **woken his host**. "**At that moment he realised: *I'm too addicted.*** From then on, never again." "**That's a real *chacham*.** That's what the Rambam means by 'addiction': **anything that forces my choices**, so I'm not fully in control."

Not just Jewish wisdom

This isn't known only from the prophets, but from the ancient sages of the nations. "The greatest of philosophers," Aristotle (in the *Ethics*): **כוונת האל בנו שנהיה נבונים וטובים**: **God's intention for us is that we be wise and good.**

Both are needed

	Verdict
Wise but chasing pleasure	**Not truly wise**: true wisdom takes from physical pleasure only what sustains the body. **Yirmeyahu**: **איכה תאמרו חכמים אנחנו ותורת ה׳ אתנו?**
Restrained and good-charactered but unlearned	**Also incomplete**: he acts rightly, but **not from conviction**, not from wisdom. (Still, the Rambam is clear: **better** good character without learning than learning without good character)
Both	**The purpose of the world**

So **אין בור ירא חטא ולא עם הארץ חסיד** (Avot 2): an ignoramus can't be truly God-fearing or pious. That's why the Torah always says **ולמדתם… ושמרתם לעשתם**: **learning before doing**. **Wisdom leads to good action; good action alone doesn't lead to wisdom. תלמוד מביא לידי מעשה.**

"Good character" here isn't just *nice middot*: "**obviously** you can't be a *chacham* with bad middot." It means **balance**: if your intellect were fully developed, **it would have come down into your actions and temperament**. A small addiction means **the intellect hasn't reached the heart**.

Part 5: "But Why Does It Matter?"

Murray asked: why is it necessary to be intellectual? *Does it mean "not an idiot," or someone who reads books all the time?*

"**Reading books, that's what we're talking about.** The ultimate book is the Torah, but **all disciplines, all sciences, all knowledge** matter, and together they bring you to knowing Hashem."

Why that matters? The Rambam takes it as self-evident. **The alternative is to entertain yourself, live 70, 80, 100 years, die, "and swim in the sea of materialism."**

"But you die anyway, intellectual or not." "**The intellect stays with you forever. Your intellect is your identity.** How many **steaks** someone ate goes to the grave with him. But a developed intellect and character reach **the core of the person**, what we call the **neshamah**, and that's **eternal**."

Does it come back at the resurrection? "No need. Whatever Mashiach, resurrection and Olam HaBa are, every one of our Sages agrees **some part of us is eternal**."

Eternity, as taught to the Rabbi as a child: "Fill **Wembley Stadium** with tiny **sunflower seeds**. Every day a bird takes **one**. Millions, perhaps billions of years. **That's eternity.**"

A further thought: "Why doesn't the Rambam say that here, when he does elsewhere? I think he's saying that **even forgetting the next world**, to live as a **human being in this world**, developing intellect and character is what distinguishes us from animals. **That's what makes us human.**"

Part 6: Then Why Create Everyone Else?

You said Divine wisdom makes nothing in vain; everything on earth is for the human; the human is for the intellect. **Then why did Hashem create all the people who never develop it? ונשארה כאן שאלה אחת.**

most people are **naked of wisdom**, chasing desires; the **רוב בני אדם ערומים מן החכמה, מבקשי תאוות**: wise, restrained person is **so rare**, a marvel, **perhaps one in a generation**.

"How much more so today." *"Most of us are running to make a living."* "That's absolutely fair, and that's actually part of his answer."

The Rambam's two answers (more next week):

1	**The others make the wise one's life possible.** If he had to **build his own house** and **weave his own clothes**, he'd have **no time** to develop himself
2	**Even the wise need society.** Alone, "**they'd be bored**." Other, different people give their lives **colour**

Summary

1. **Everything has a purpose**: obvious, discoverable, or knowable only by prophecy. **Shlomo** knew them all. **Unknown uses reflect our ignorance**; each generation discovers more.
2. **Everything *on Earth*** (not the whole universe, against Rav Saadia) **is for the human.**
3. **The human's one purpose: ציור המושכלות**, grasping truth, crowned by **knowing Hashem's unity**. Eating, building, ruling: **animals do those too**. **Before developing his intellect, a person is like an animal.**
4. It requires **self-denial**: not asceticism (the Rambam hated it) but **priorities**, as in exams: **אדם כי ימות באהל**. Otherwise you're "**swimming in the sea of matter**."
5. **The purpose of the world is a person both wise and good**, with **no addictions** (**the Chida's snuff**). Aristotle agrees: **"wise and good."** Learning comes **first**, because it leads to action.
6. **The intellect is eternal**: steaks aren't. And even in this world, **it's what makes us human**.

7. **Why so many others?** They **sustain** the wise and give them **society**. More next week.

Coming Up

Next week: the two answers in depth, and then, finally, **"the four cubits of halachah."**

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